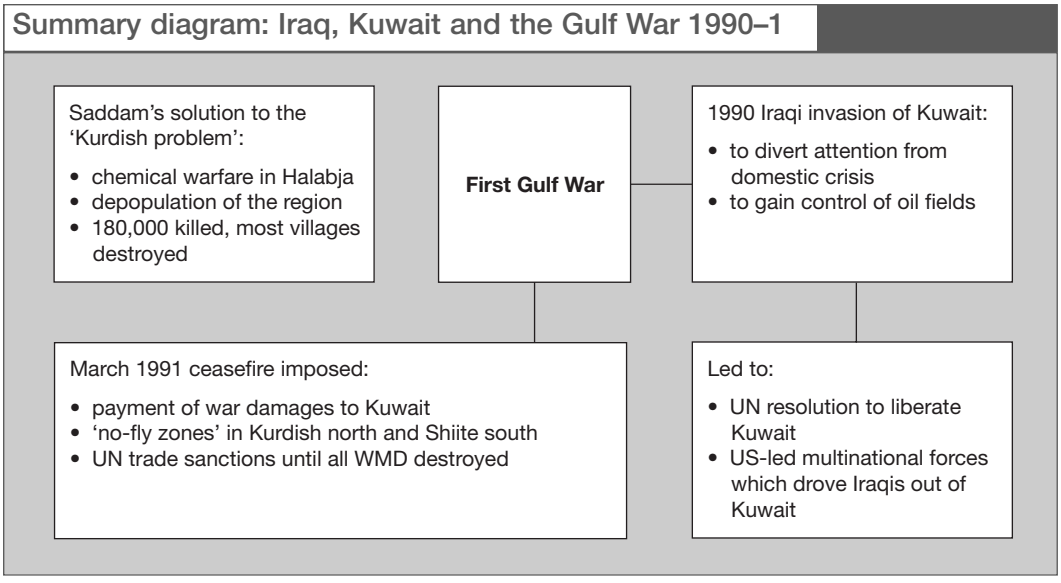


2 | The UN, the USA and the Invasion of Iraq 2003

The search for weapons of mass destruction

Key question
What evidence of WMD did UN inspectors find?

One month after the ceasefire, the UN formed a special committee (**UNSCOM**) to search for and destroy Iraq's WMD. Until all those weapons had been destroyed, trade sanctions would be imposed on Iraq. A wide variety of imports were banned. At first, this pressure worked: Iraq co-operated and admitted that it had stockpiled nerve gas and chemical warheads while the UN inspectors uncovered a nuclear programme with several kilograms of highly enriched uranium, necessary for the production of nuclear weapons.

After a year UNSCOM declared that it had destroyed all medium- and long-range missiles and, three years later, that it had destroyed all the material for making nuclear and chemical weapons. However, it had not been able to eliminate all of Iraq's biological weapons programme. Nevertheless, by 1995, the Iraqi government was confident that sanctions would soon be lifted and confessed to the production of some anthrax and nerve gas while claiming that the stockpiles had been destroyed during the Gulf War. UNSCOM demanded proof but this was not forthcoming.

At this time, Saddam's son-in-law, who had fallen out of favour with Saddam because of a family feud, defected to Jordan. He told those who questioned him in Jordan that, after the Gulf War, Saddam's second son had been given the job of hiding Iraq's WMD. (He was later promised a pardon by Saddam and returned to Baghdad, only to be shot three days later. His uncle said: 'We have cut off the treacherous branch from our noble family tree'.) The Americans were now increasingly suspicious and distrustful of the Iraqi government and they began to demand **'regime change'**

Key terms

UNSCOM
UN special committee set up to search for and destroy Iraq's WMD.

'Regime change'
Change in the system of government (in this case, Saddam's dictatorship).